

Figure 1

Australian Islamic Centre, Newport

Walker, P. (2019, July 31). *Radical and poetic: 'Australian Islamic Centre of Newport'* (Photograph). *ARCHITECUREAU.* https://architectureau.com/articles/australian-islamic-centre-of-newport/

How the significant role of sustainability was a large factor throughout the construction process of Glenn Murcatt's Australian Islamic Centre?

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The Australian Islamic Centre, Newport built in 2019 is the first successful Australian Mosque that defines a new and improved architectural infrastructure for the Islamic community based in the Western Suburbs of Melbourne (NGV, 2016). The unique, functional and powerful design of the Australian Islamic Centre represents the connective relationship of the Islamic community in our modernised society today. The large 10,000 m2 area displays the importance and the need for the Islamic centre in the community. The Australian Islamic Centre was designed by one of Australia's award-winning and well-renowned architects, Glenn Murcutt (NGV, 2018). Throughout the design process, Murcutt has utilised the modern-day principles and also responds to the Islamic community's traditional and religious needs. Murcutt has exceeded expectations and challenged the semiotic language of a traditional mosque by reconsidering the transparency, geometry, colours, design and tradition of the Islamic Centre Mosque (NGV, 2018). Glenn Murcutt is a Pritzker Architecture prize winner and one of Australia's most respected Architects. He is most known for designing innovative climate-sensitive private houses/buildings and using sustainable materials during the construction process. An example of this is within his design of the Australian Islamic Centre.



Figure 2

Browell, A. (2019, March 18) "*Australian Islamic Centre"* (Photograph). Building Centre. https://www.buildingcentre.co.uk/news/articles/australian-islamic-centre

How Glenn Murcutt utilised a holistic approach to sustainability throughout the design of the Australian Islamic Centre, Newport. Glenn Murcutt had never designed anything of this uniqueness before and had limited experience with the Australian Muslim community (Nguyen 2023). When Murcutt was offered the job to design the mosque the feelings of excitement and happiness consumed him but that was soon taken over by stress and nerves. Murcatt, (2018) “wanted to work with an architect from an Islamic background, in equal collaboration. Hakan Elevli, (2018) was suggested, a meeting took place and he joined the project” (Archdaily 2019). To meet sustainability needs Murcatt (2018) utilised a holistic approach, focusing on the economic, social and environmental approaches to sustainability throughout the design of the Islamic centre (Nguyen, 2023). Murcutt appealed to economic sustainability by designing a project that would be sustainable and successful by leaving positive long-term impacts. Murcutt was beneficial in balancing financial success with social and environmental considerations which develop sustainable economic growth that benefits the Islamic community. The next step in the holistic approach is social sustainability which refers to the well-being and empowerment of individuals, communities and society. By Murutt appealing to social sustainability, it promoted diversity, inclusion and human rights which develops the social relationships between the people involved within the community. A stronger community equals a stronger society. Murcutt designed the mosque by utilising facilities such as a congregational hall, library, cafe, kitchen, sporting ground and also a secluded space for Muslim women (Nguyen, 2023). Throughout this design, Murcutt intended to create a facility where the members of the Islamic community can gather and create meaningful relationships with one another. The final step in the holistic approach that Murcutt utilised in the design of the Mosque was environmental sustainability (Nguyen, 2023). Throughout the construction process, Murcutt utilised specific sustainable materials in order

to create a positive impact on the environment and allow for a sufficient and functional building. Murcutt proceeded to choose a wide variety of materials for the Mosque to enhance and add uniqueness to the design. The main material was concrete which provides energy efficiency, has a long life cycle and low life cycle costs. He also chose to include blue glass walls and clear windows to add natural daylight within the interior of the Mosque which would help decrease energy consumption from lights as there would be a large opening where daylight can reach. Overall Glenn Murcutt (2018) utilised an efficient holistic approach to sustainability when designing the Australian Islamic Centre.

How Glenn Murcutt successfully fulfilled the role and met the cultural needs of the Muslim community via the completion of the Australian Islamic Centre. When Murcatt was offered the job of designing the Mosque, he had no previous experience in the designs of Islamic buildings and also no experience working with the Australian Islamic community. As previously mentioned, Glenn Murcutt was offered to work with an experienced architect from an Islamic background, Hakan Elevli (McEoin, 2016). Murcutt and Elevli worked with the Newport Islamic Council for nearly a decade, designing the beautiful Mosque to the best of their capabilities. Murcutt's experience and Elevli's Islamic knowledge made for a successful design of the Australian Islamic Centre. Several needs of the Islamic Community would need to be met throughout the design of the Islamic Centre. Some being, a large gathering centre for prayer and functions, a small prayer room, a cafe/diner, a kitchen, a separate department for women, a sporting facility and other needs were to be met. The Australian Islamic Centre grew from being just a place of worship to a large centre with services that cater to the Islamic community needs in society. Murcutt and Elevli were successful in designing a mosque that caters for the Islamic community and now the Australian Islamic Centre is a Mosque that is recognised all around the world.

All in all the role of sustainability was a large factor throughout the construction process of Glenn Murcutt's design of the Australian Islamic Centre, Newport. Glenn Murcutt utilised a holistic approach, to economic, social and environmental sustainability throughout the design of the Australian Islamic Centre. He appealed to each holistic approach in the appropriate manner, allowing him to design a functional and successful Islamic Mosque.

There was a large demand of needs that would have had to be met via the Islamic community when designing the Mosque, it not only had to be an average place for prayer, but an extremely large building with several facilities and services on offer for local Muslims. Glenn Murcutt worked with Islamic architect Hakan Elevli to produce the extraordinary Australian Islamic Centre.



Figure 3

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